There is little doubt that of the four major formations in the fray, AAP is the one that represents change—that has also been the leitmotif of its campaign. And there's some resonance on the ground for its overall vibe: that AAP is a baggage-free, as-yet-untainted entity and, given a chance, would prove its worth. The sentiment cuts across age groups. That Mann was getting voter traction was evident when he took out a long vehicular rally that began in Anandpur Sahib and wended its way through major towns in the Doaba region. In every town, enthusiastic workers joined the convoy in trademark Punjab fashion—on tractors with disco lights flashing and speakers blaring patriotic songs about Bhagat Singh, and restless lines of cars and two-wheelers carrying AAP flags. Mann stood atop an SUV waving his hands and accepting garlands tossed towards him. The Bhagat Singh addition is a nice touch, for Mann has often mentioned that he is inspired by the freedom fighter and had taken a pledge in front of his portrait before his swearing-in at the Lok Sabha in 2014. He now sports a basanti-coloured turban as a symbol of his admiration for him. The spring, the mustard fields... all the metaphors seemed to be coming together for him.

Yet Mann will need more than high symbolism—and more substance to his vision than is contained in the bunch of freebies that AAP is promising—to win over the electorate. In 2017, AAP seemed poised to sweep the polls but flattered to deceive. In the end, it did get an impressive 24 per cent vote share, but found itself with only 20 seats. This time, the party is being doubly cautious, with minders from Delhi controlling Mann's movements and interviews to prevent any snafu like the one Kejriwal caused in 2017, when he was seen courting people with Khalistani links. The Hindu voters then rallied around the Congress, and brought it victory. Mann is focusing on unemployment, but the actual agenda for job creation seems unclear. As Kumar points out, "Change cannot be brought merely by exchanging a blue turban for the white topi of AAP. The party is now packed with dropouts from all other parties—what's the change?" That's the question Mann and his compatriots will have to answer well before the polling date of February 20.



A FAMILIAR FACE
SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal on the Rajpura-Patiala highway